

How Earth formed

Earth was created from rock fragments, dust, and gas orbiting the early Sun. As this material smashed together, it heated up, until the whole mass melted. The heavier metals sank towards the center of the young planet to become its core, leaving the rest to form its thick rocky mantle, crust, and atmosphere.

▼ SPINNING DISK
The whole Solar System was formed from a cloud of dust and rock called the solar nebula.

ACCRETION

Earth and all the planets were made in the same way, from the giant spinning disk of rock and dust left over from the formation of the Sun. The rocks collided and became welded together in larger lumps—a process called accretion. The lumps joined together to form several small planets. As each one grew, it developed the gravity to attract more and more material, until there was no more within its range.

FACT!

Earth's mass is still growing as chunks of space rock called meteorites hit its surface. Luckily, Jupiter's immense gravity attracts most of the bigger objects and stops them from hitting us.